

Orgasms

An orgasm is a climax of sexual activity. After a period of sexual arousal, partners might reach orgasm (separately or together), experiencing a rush of pleasurable feelings. A person generally feels a sense of sexual release and relaxation afterward.

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Arousal

A person can become sexually aroused by being in a sexual situation with, or by fantasizing about, another person. What and who stimulates a person to feel aroused is unique to them. During sexual arousal, blood flow to the genitals increases, causing the penis to become erect and the clitoris to swell and become more sensitive. The millions of nerve endings send messages to the hypothalamus, which then releases more endorphins, the body's natural feel-good hormones.



△ Building pleasure

A period of arousal can last from a few minutes to several hours.

Orgasms

When arousal reaches a climax, known as an orgasm, a person experiences an intense rush of pleasure and release, followed by relaxation. During orgasm, the brain is flooded with oxytocin, a hormone that causes people to feel intimate with their partner, and dopamine, which creates feelings of pleasure. An orgasm is almost always accompanied by ejaculation (a release of fluid) in males, and occasionally in females.



△ Intense pleasure

An orgasm can feel like a release of control and can be accompanied by an explosion of pleasure.

Talking things through

Different people have things that they find pleasurable and other things that they don't find pleasurable at all. Talking this through with a sexual partner shouldn't be a cause for embarrassment. What each person finds sexual or pleasurable varies greatly, so it's important to chat about intimacy and what feels good.

▷ Open and honest

If something doesn't feel good, both people should be honest.



GOOD TO KNOW

Faking orgasms

Some people fake orgasms due to the pressure they feel to be able to orgasm, or because they are worried about hurting their partner's feelings. However, lying about orgasms can negatively affect future sexual activity with that partner. It's always better to be honest.